

Rain and reinforcements

Tracking the tournament from ground zero, our correspondents bring you the IPL's **off-field stories**, where the real drama often brews away from the spotlight.

It is unrealistic to place a cricket stadium in a place called Barsapara and expect rain not to have a say in proceedings. It literally translates to 'rain neighbourhood.'

The name proved prophetic, as all three IPL 2026 games allotted to the stadium in Guwahati bore rain's imprint in varying shades.

Storm watch: Barsapara under watchful clouds, the stadium lights cutting through as another rain-interrupted evening looms. PRANAY RAJIV

The Diary was on site for the second game, between the designated home team Rajasthan Royals and Mumbai Indians.

There was nothing portentous in the weather forecast for match day. After a hearty lunch — an Assamese duck curry thali — the Diary spotted a smattering of clouds from the hotel, located just a few 100 metres away from the stadium.

Still no cause for worry, and there was enough time to squeeze in a power nap. But the Diary was shaken awake at around 4:30 PM by a loud rumble. The sight from the hotel terrace was near-apocalyptic. Rain-bearing

